the operation. But for those officers who genuinely tried to catch Sivarasan alive, it was salt rubbed on their wounds, for they could not see any victory in the spectacle that was created due to the complete lack of coordination between the various agencies.[12]

Naturally there were excuses galore that had come from the officers. While Vijay Karan avoided the press, Kaarthikeyan was at his diplomatic best. For him, 'it was next to impossible to catch Sivarasan and Shubha alive', although he was in agreement with the officers who wanted to storm the hideout at Konanakunte on 18 August, when Mridula had informed the police about Sivarasan's presence in the house. Saritha Rai from *India Today*'s Bangalore bureau and Anirudhya went on to write that the 'SIT, the Bangalore police and the think tanks of the operation representing various agencies had slipped on a banana peel while at a shouting distance of Rajiv Gandhi's assassin'. When Anirudhya asked Ramalingam why his force could not conduct the operation without drawing the attention of the public, and particularly the fugitives, he had no answer except 'we did our best'. But Anirudhya had heard that Ramalingam wanted to raid the hideout soon after he got wind of Sivarasan's whereabouts on the afternoon of 18 August. But he had got cold feet after hearing from Mridula that Sivarasan carried an assault rifle. He had feared a violent retaliation from the fugitive. So the commissioner had played safe. He had left it to the CBI to decide when to raid the house. Anirudhya chased the commissioner for the next hour, trying to get a comment. He finally came up with one: 'All members of the tracking team knew catching Sivarasan alive would be impossible. The fugitives would have taken the cyanide in any case. Therefore, we acted as per the demand of the situation.'[13]

What was even more intriguing was that neither the CBI nor the Bangalore Police gave the NSG Black Cats a chance to execute their plan of storming the house and catching Sivarasan alive. All in thirty seconds maximum. In any case, neither the local police nor any member of the SIT or the CBI was to physically raid the hideout. It was for the NSG to break into. But the Black Cats were never given the green signal even though they waited for thirty-six long hours. After the bodies had been taken out, the